



YOU SAID IT

Debian vs Ubuntu: A personal experience



I recently read the Debian 6.0 review published in the March 2011 edition of *LINUX For You*. I also installed the DVD of Debian 6.0 on my system and used it for two weeks. As an ordinary home user, I would like to share my observations related to my experience of Debian 6.0. I changed from Fedora to Ubuntu in 2007 after successive releases of Fedora became more and more unfriendly to the home user. Ubuntu was fine up to its 9.04 version. From 9.10 onwards, the Ubuntu development team seems to have been bitten by the bug to come up with the 'latest' edition, frequently, and has developed a target-chasing psyche. I got fed up with the imperfections and unpleasant surprises in Ubuntu. The arrival of Debian 6.0 is a welcome relief. Here are some of my observations on the distro:

- The time taken to install it is double that required for Ubuntu 10.10, but is a pleasure since it's a smooth ride with crystal clear screen instructions and displays, and is more comprehensive.
- Ext-4 file system is very much available as a choice.
- Manual partitioning is more fool-proof than in Ubuntu.
- Start-up time is faster than Ubuntu, which is a flat 80 seconds.
- It includes better help tips.
- There are no unpleasant surprises.
- Even without non-free software, there was no problem for the utilities I was earlier using on Ubuntu 10.04/10.10.
- My pet utility, 'Audacity', which never worked in Ubuntu 9.10 to 10.10, runs smoothly in Debian 6.0.
- For those who attach more importance to non-essentials like the appearance of windows, icons,

splash screen, themes, etc, Debian 6 is as good as, or even a little better than Ubuntu.

I am happy that now I do not have to go through the turmoil of installing the 'latest' Ubuntu version every six months. At release 9.04, I had hoped that one day soon, Ubuntu would beat Windows back on the home user front, but am now convinced that it will not. It's up to Debian or some other flavour of Linux to achieve that.

The only shortfall I encountered in Debian, so far, is the less extensive Indian language support compared to Ubuntu. For example, I am not able to get Kannada transliteration, which is shown in the Debian website as still under development. I wonder why they cannot borrow such things from Ubuntu and refine it instead of re-inventing the wheel.

—Eddy Karkada, eddykabootar@yahoo.com

ED: Thanks for sharing your views on Debian 6 and Ubuntu. We appreciate the time and effort that you've taken and are sure our readers will find this Debian-Ubuntu comparison interesting. Please do keep sharing your feedback/suggestions/observations with us in the future too.

Do publish more admin-related articles



I am a regular reader of *LFY* magazine. No doubt, it is the best magazine on open source. But I have a few suggestions to make. It would be good if you included articles on topics related to networking and to Linux systems administration, like NFS and NIS file systems and devices.

—Venkataramana K, venkataramana_k@in.com

ED: Thanks for writing in. We would like to apprise you that we do cover topics related to network monitoring and management tools, on a regular basis. I wondered if you have read the recent series of articles on NMap, Backtrack, et al. I am sure you will be glad to know that the theme for the June edition of *LFY* is 'Network management, monitoring and programming, using open source apps'. We hope that you will find this edition useful. So keep reading *LFY*! Do let us know if you have any other query or suggestions.

Request for a contents-related quiz



I have been a regular reader of *LINUX For You* from its early days. *LFY* is a magazine that has inspired me to jump into the world of Linux. It is not surprising to note the rate at which the readership of the magazine has grown. The key reason behind the popularity of the magazine is its quality. The articles, such as 'Securing Apache', 'Better Queries with MySQL', the Python series, and 'Tips & Tricks', are extremely good. Articles relevant to enterprises, such as the one on Selenium IDE, were also very good. I always look forward to receiving the next edition of the magazine to read the continuation of these articles. Whenever I receive the latest edition of the magazine, I can't decide which article to read first. I do have a small suggestion or, rather, a request. It might be a good idea for the *LFY* team to create a quiz or puzzles based on the articles published in a particular edition, to engage readers.

Finally, a 'Big Thanks' for the Debian 6 DVD shipped with the March 2011 edition of *LFY*.

—Arumugham V, arumughamv@gmail.com